If PVB has actor Vijay Deverakonda and K.L. Rahul as team owners and shuttlers Sindhu and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy as fans, then the Pro Panja League, India's premier arm-wrestling league, which took off in 2023, has actor Parvinn Dabass as a co-founder. Dabass has made it a mission to turn this 'pastime' of college canteens and idle mohallas into a serious pursuit. "It's a very technique-based sport," he says. "The feeling of beating somebody... you walk out with a certain swag, it's what people really relate to." The league, he adds, aims to build a "community" and "a movement to uplift arm-wrestling".

A STRONG ARM, ANYONE?

Dabass takes pride in the league's inclusivity—women are participants, and there is a category for the differently-abled. Its real appeal lies in the backgrounds of the athletes. Apart from usual suspects like fitness trainers, there have been athletes from varied walks of life—a factory worker, a teacher, a rickshaw driver, a chartered accountant and even a housewife, Farheen Dehalvi, who credits her proficiency in sport to housework. It has also made stars out of individuals like Mizoram's Denic Lalruattluanga Vangchhia, who went from Panja League to win a silver in the World Arm Wrestling Cup and later acted in a Mizo film. "We have taught arm wrestlers how to use social media, become influencers and earn an income," adds Dabass, citing the popularity of Gwalior's Sachin Goyal, who goes as 'Bicep King' and has over 2.5 million followers. Dabass hopes to add more teams in future editions as well as taking the league outside India.

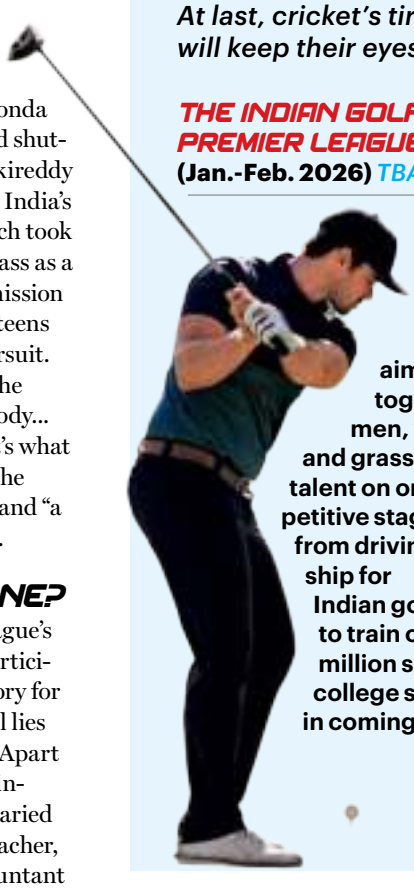
Most crucially, sports leagues are a means to measure India's top tier of athletes vis-à-vis international ones, like during the Archery Premier League, which was held in New Delhi in October. APL drew top-ranked men's and women's compound archers as well as recurve Olympic champion Mete Gazoz and Paris Games silver medalist Brady Ellison. To make the ancient sport more broadcast-friendly, the competition was held under lights and the time given for each shot at target was reduced from 20 to 15 seconds, heightening excitement. "We have won world competitions, except at the Olympics. We are trying to understand what we should do that we haven't done," says APL chairman. Training and interacting with and competing against international athletes would surely have benefited Indian archers.

The opportunity to learn from foreign counterparts is what makes the Ultimate Table Tennis League a much-anticipated event in the calendar for India team paddler Sreeja Akula. "We exchange ideas and see what they do in training," she told India Today in an interview in 2024. "We know their game, which helps us in international tournaments when we play them."

Archery is not the only sport to get a spectator-friendly spin. Golf, too, is experimenting with the league

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THE INDIAN GOLF PREMIER LEAGUE

(Jan.-Feb. 2026) *TBA**

In its inaugural edition, the event aims to bring together men, women and grassroots talent on one competitive stage. Apart from driving viewership for Indian golf, it aims to train over 1 million school and college students in coming years.



ANI

INDIAN PICKLEBALL LEAGUE

(Dec 1-7) *New Delhi*

The fast-growing fitness and lifestyle sport giving tennis a run for its money in the US made its big screen and streaming debut in India with the IPBL. Star paddlers like Mihika Yadav and Aman Patel



> **"PLAYERS GET EXPOSURE IN THE PRIME VOLLEYBALL LEAGUE AND THE ECOSYSTEM DEVELOPS—REFEREES, LINESMEN, TRAINERS. RECOGNITION IS IMPORTANT, TOO"**
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